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NOT CONSUMED

Sin Took the Covering.
Mercy Would Not Let Go.

His compassions fail not. They are new every morning.

OLADAPO OLALEYE

BOOK THREE · THE LIBRARY

Not Consumed: Sin Took the Covering. Mercy Would Not Let Go.

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Introduction

The book of Lamentations is not comfortable reading, and it was never meant to be. It is five chapters of a man watching a city he loved lie in ruins, and refusing to look away from why. Jerusalem did not fall because God stopped being God. It fell because a covenant people had worn away, sin by sin, the covering that had kept the enemy out — until one day there was nothing left standing between them and everything they had feared.

And yet the very center of that book, verse 22 of chapter 3, holds the line that changes everything: "It is of the LORD's mercies that we are not consumed, because his compassions fail not." Not because the sin was small. Not because it wasn't deserved. Because mercy held, even when the covering was gone.

This book sits inside that tension on purpose. It will not soften what sin actually costs — the real exposure, the real losses, the real ground given up to an enemy who does not negotiate. But it will not stop there either, because Lamentations doesn't stop there. It walks all the way to the cross, where the covering sin tore away was finally, fully restored — not patched, replaced. Not earned back, given. The faithfulness Jeremiah wept over in a ruined city is the same faithfulness that held a cross together for us.

Eight chapters, each built on scripture, each one following the line from loss to mercy. Read a chapter a day, or read it in one sitting — either way, come ready to be honest about what sin has cost, and ready to be amazed at what it did not take. This is Book Three

in the Library — a new title from Word and Faith Network every two weeks.

CHAPTER ONE

The Covering We Were Given

> *"And they were both naked, the man and his wife, and were not ashamed."*
>
> GENESIS 2:25 — KJV

Before we can understand what sin takes, we have to understand what we were given in the first place. Genesis 2:25 describes a condition that sounds, at first, almost unremarkable — the man and his wife were naked, and unashamed. But read slowly, this is one of the most extraordinary statements in all of scripture. Two people stood fully exposed, fully known, with nothing hidden — and felt no fear, no shame, no need to cover anything at all.

That was not an accident of innocence. It was a covering of a different kind — not cloth, but relationship. Adam and Eve were covered by the nearness of God Himself. They walked with Him in the cool of the day (Genesis 3:8) the way a child walks beside a parent, unafraid, because nothing stood between them. Their nakedness was not vulnerability; it was intimacy. The covering was His presence, and under it, nothing about them needed to be hidden.

This is the picture we have to hold onto before we go any further, because everything in the chapters ahead — every consequence, every exposure, every tear in the fabric — only makes sense against this starting point. We were never designed to live exposed and afraid. We were designed to live covered: safe in God's nearness, hidden in Him even while fully seen by Him.

> *"Thou art my hiding place; thou shalt preserve me from trouble; thou shalt compass me about with songs of deliverance."*
>
> **PSALM 32:7, KJV**

It helps to notice what "covering" means throughout scripture, because it is not a minor theme — it runs from Genesis to Revelation. To be covered is to be shielded from exposure, from accusation, from the elements that would otherwise harm you. Psalm 91 describes it as dwelling "in the secret place of the most High," abiding "under the shadow of the Almighty" (v.1) — language that assumes a real danger outside, and a real safety inside. The covering is not decoration. It is the only thing standing between a person and the forces that would consume them.

This is why Eden is the right place to begin a book about sin's consequences and God's mercy, rather than jumping straight to Lamentations' ruins. We cannot feel the weight of what was lost unless we first see what was there to lose. A people who have never known a true covering do not grieve its absence — they simply assume exposure is normal. But scripture insists otherwise: exposure was never the design. It was the deviation.

There is something worth sitting with here about how God Himself defines covering throughout the Old Testament sacrificial system. The Hebrew word often translated "atonement," *kaphar*, carries the root sense of covering over — to make a covering, to shield from view. Even before sin entered the story, God's relationship with humanity already modeled the pattern His whole redemptive plan would later follow: nearness that covers, protection that comes from proximity to Him rather than anything we manufacture ourselves.

So hold this starting image firmly: two people, fully known, fully exposed to each other and to God, and entirely unafraid — because the covering over them was not something they wore, but someone they walked with. Whatever we find broken in the chapters ahead, this is the condition it broke. And whatever restoration we find at the end of this book, this is the condition it restores us toward — not merely forgiveness, but a return to walking covered, unashamed, in the nearness of God.

CHAPTER TWO

When the Covering Tears

> *"And the eyes of them both were opened, and they knew that they were naked; and they sewed fig leaves together, and made themselves aprons."*
>
> GENESIS 3:7 — KJV

The same two people, the same bodies, the same garden — and yet everything has changed in a single verse. Genesis 3:7 does not say their bodies were altered. It says their eyes were opened, and what they suddenly saw was their own nakedness, where a moment before there had been none to see. Sin did not add something to Adam and Eve. It removed something: the covering of unbroken nearness to God that had made their exposure invisible to them.

This is the pattern sin always follows, and Lamentations will show us its full, devastating scale later in this book: sin does not merely break a rule. It tears a covering. It opens eyes to a vulnerability that was always physically present but was, until that moment, entirely shielded by relationship. The moment the relationship fractured, the exposure that had always technically existed suddenly became felt, visible, and frightening.

Notice their first response: not repentance, but concealment. "They sewed fig leaves together, and made themselves aprons" — a desperate, human attempt to replace a covering they could not undo themselves. This is worth lingering on, because it is the first recorded religious act in human history, and it fails. Fig leaves wither. Self-made coverings cannot hold against what they are

meant to shield against. Every attempt since then to cover our own exposure — through achievement, performance, denial, distraction — has been some version of the same fig leaf, and has failed for the same reason.

> *"We all do fade as a leaf; and our iniquities, like the wind, have taken us away."*
>
> **ISAIAH 64:6, KJV**

Lamentations will later describe the fall of Jerusalem in strikingly similar terms to this scene in Eden — nakedness exposed, shame uncovered, a people suddenly seeing what sin had already made true long before it became visible. "Jerusalem... is removed: all that honoured her despise her, because they have seen her nakedness" (Lamentations 1:8). The city's walls, the temple's protection, the covenant's covering — all of it had been quietly worn through long before Babylon's armies arrived. The enemy did not create the exposure. The enemy simply walked through a tear that had already opened, one sin at a time, long before anyone was watching.

This is the sobering truth this chapter has to name honestly: sin's first casualty is almost never the dramatic consequence we eventually see. It is the quiet tearing of a covering that nobody notices right away — the small compromise, the private disobedience, the slow drift from nearness — each one a thread pulled loose, invisible until enough threads are gone that the whole garment gives way at once.

It is worth asking, honestly, what fig leaves we have been sewing. Where have we tried to manufacture our own covering — through busyness, reputation, achievement, or simply looking away —

rather than returning to the one relationship that actually shields us? Fig leaves are not evil in themselves; they are simply insufficient, a human substitute for a divine covering that only God can restore. Chapter five of this book will show us exactly what He did about that. But first, Lamentations requires us to look honestly at what the tear costs — which is where we go next.

CHAPTER THREE

Trampled by the Enemy

> *"The adversary hath spread out his hand upon all her pleasant things: for she hath seen that the heathen entered into her sanctuary."*
>
> LAMENTATIONS 1:10 — KJV

Lamentations does not describe sin in the abstract. It describes what sin actually produces when it is left unaddressed long enough: a city, once protected, now trampled by exactly the kind of enemy its covering had been keeping out. "How doth the city sit solitary, that was full of people!" the book opens (1:1) — a line that only makes sense if we remember what that city once was, and what stood guard over it before.

This chapter asks us to take seriously something many believers would rather skip past quickly: sin has an actual enemy standing ready to exploit it, not a metaphorical one. "Be sober, be vigilant; because your adversary the devil, as a roaring lion, walketh about, seeking whom he may devour" (1 Peter 5:8). A lion does not stalk the strong, guarded, and covered. It watches for the exposed, the separated, the one who has wandered from the protection of the herd. Sin does not merely offend God in the abstract — it creates the exact conditions an adversary is waiting for.

> *"Mine enemies chased me sore, like a bird, without cause... Thou hast heard my voice: hide not thine ear at my sighing, at my cry."*
>
> LAMENTATIONS 3:52,56, KJV

Lamentations 1:16 says it plainly: "for these things I weep; mine eye, mine eye runneth down with water, because the comforter that should relieve my soul is far from me: my children are desolate, because the enemy prevailed." Notice the order of causation the verse itself gives: the comforter is far — the covering had already withdrawn — and only then does the enemy prevail. The enemy's victory was never really a contest of strength. It was an opportunity created by an absence.

This matters enormously for how we understand our own seasons of being overwhelmed, attacked, or worn down. It is tempting, in such seasons, to focus entirely on the enemy's aggression — and there is real aggression to name and resist (Ephesians 6:11-12). But Lamentations insists we also ask the harder question: what covering had quietly gone missing before the trouble arrived? Not to manufacture guilt over every hardship — some suffering has nothing to do with our own sin, as Job's story makes clear. But some does, and pretending otherwise leaves us fighting symptoms while the actual breach stays open.

The language of being "trampled" is deliberately physical and humiliating. Lamentations 1:15 says, "The Lord hath trodden under foot all my mighty men in the midst of me" — the imagery of a vineyard crushed in the wine-press, of something valuable reduced to pulp underfoot. This is what the loss of covering actually feels like from the inside: not a single dramatic blow, but an ongoing crushing, a steady loss of dignity and strength, exactly as the prophet describes it, exactly as it feels when we have drifted from the nearness that once protected us.

It would be easy to let this chapter end in despair, and Lamentations itself spends most of its five chapters in exactly this kind of unflinching grief, because grief over real loss is not weakness — it is honesty. But the very same book that describes the trampling in such detail also contains, right at its center, the

turn this book is named for. We are not left in chapter three's trampling. We go there next.

CHAPTER FOUR

Yet Not Consumed

> *"It is of the LORD's mercies that we are not consumed, because his compassions fail not. They are new every morning: great is thy faithfulness."*
>
> LAMENTATIONS 3:22-23 — KJV

This is the hinge the entire book of Lamentations turns on, and the hinge this book is built around. For two and a half chapters, Jeremiah has described devastation in some of the rawest language in all of scripture — starvation, siege, humiliation, grief with no bottom to it. And then, in the exact middle of the book, without the circumstances changing at all, he writes the line that reframes everything: "it is of the LORD's mercies that we are not consumed."

Notice precisely what this verse does and does not say. It does not say the judgment wasn't deserved — the surrounding chapters make clear it was. It does not say the consequences were undone — the city was still in ruins as Jeremiah wrote this. What it says is narrower, and more remarkable: whatever was lost, whatever was deserved, the people were not consumed. Something held. Something stopped the judgment from becoming total annihilation. That something was not the strength of the people. It was the mercy of the One they had sinned against.

> *"The LORD is merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and plenteous in mercy... He will not always chide: neither will he keep his anger for ever."*

PSALM 103:8-9, KJV

This is the distinction scripture draws consistently between discipline and destruction, and it is essential to hold onto here. "For whom the Lord loveth he chasteneth" (Hebrews 12:6) — discipline is real, and Lamentations does not soften it. But discipline has a floor that destruction does not. A loving father disciplines his child precisely because he intends for that child to still be standing afterward. Lamentations 3:31-33 makes this explicit: "For the Lord will not cast off for ever: but though he cause grief, yet will he have compassion according to the multitude of his mercies... for he doth not afflict willingly." The grief is real. The compassion underneath it is more real still, and it is what keeps the grief from becoming the final word.

It is worth asking why Jeremiah places this declaration of mercy in the center of a book otherwise devoted to grief, rather than at the very end as a tidy resolution. The placement itself teaches something: mercy is not merely the conclusion we reach once the suffering is over. It is the ground we are already standing on in the middle of it, even while the ruins are still smoking, even while nothing visible has changed yet. "Not consumed" was true the day Jeremiah wrote it — not a promise for someday, but a present fact underneath present pain.

This is also where the chapter's final phrase deserves full weight: "great is thy faithfulness." Not great is thy leniency, as though God simply overlooks sin. Faithfulness — the steady, covenant-keeping character of God that does not waver based on how badly His people have behaved. The mercy that kept Jerusalem from total consumption was not an emotional impulse. It was the faithful outworking of who God has always said He is: slow to anger, plenteous in mercy, not willing that any should perish (2 Peter 3:9).

Hold this verse the way Jeremiah clearly held it — not as an excuse to minimize what sin costs, which the previous two chapters have made unmistakably clear, but as the one unshakeable fact standing in the middle of the wreckage. Whatever your own covering has cost you, whatever the enemy has trampled, you are reading this chapter instead of being swallowed by it. That is not an accident. It is of the LORD's mercies.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Better Covering

> *"He hath clothed me with the garments of salvation, he hath covered me with the robe of righteousness."*
>
> ISAIAH 61:10 — KJV

Lamentations 3 told us we were not consumed. It did not yet tell us how the covering itself would be restored — that answer comes centuries later, and it comes in a Person rather than a policy. Isaiah 61:10 describes exactly what Adam and Eve's fig leaves failed to accomplish and what no human effort since has accomplished either: a covering made and given by God Himself, not sewn together out of what we had on hand.

This is not a patch over the old tear. It is a replacement garment, described in the strongest possible terms — "garments of salvation," "the robe of righteousness." Where Eden's original covering was relational nearness, and the fig leaves were a desperate human substitute, this covering is something else entirely: righteousness itself, worn like clothing, covering what sin had stripped bare, not by hiding it but by genuinely answering it.

Jesus Himself tells this exact story in miniature through the parable of the prodigal son. The younger son returns home in rags, having spent everything, rehearsing a speech about being made a servant rather than a son (Luke 15:18-19). But before he can even finish the speech, his father runs to him, and the first thing he does is call for "the best robe" to be put on him (v.22) — not a servant's garment, the finest one in the house. The son's own coverings — his effort, his plan, his bargained-for

servanthood — are set aside entirely. What covers him is given, not earned, and given before he has done anything to deserve it beyond simply coming home.

> *"But put ye on the Lord Jesus Christ, and make not provision for the flesh, to fulfil the lusts thereof."*
>
> **ROMANS 13:14, KJV**

Paul's instruction in Romans 13:14 uses the same clothing language deliberately: "put ye on the Lord Jesus Christ." This is not a metaphor for moral improvement. It is the New Testament's answer to the fig-leaf problem that began in Eden. Every attempt to cover our own exposure through willpower, performance, or self-manufactured righteousness eventually withers, the same way fig leaves wither. But Christ, put on like a garment, does not wither — because what covers us is His own righteousness, not our own.

This is worth sitting with carefully, because it reframes what "the better covering" actually is. It is not merely forgiveness for what was done, though it includes that. It is a restored condition — the exposure itself answered, not just excused. "For he hath made him to be sin for us, who knew no sin; that we might be made the righteousness of God in him" (2 Corinthians 5:21). The exchange is total: our exposure for His covering, our shame for His righteousness, our nakedness for His robe.

Remember what Genesis 3:21 shows us, even in the middle of judgment: "Unto Adam also and to his wife did the LORD God make coats of skins, and clothed them." Even as He pronounced the consequences of their sin, God Himself provided the covering they could not make for themselves — at the cost of a life, a

shadow of the far greater covering to come. The pattern was set in the garden and fulfilled at the cross: God does not merely tell us to cover ourselves better. He covers us Himself, at His own cost, because no fig leaf we could ever sew was going to be enough.

CHAPTER SIX

A Mercy That Does Not Change

> *"If we believe not, yet he abideth faithful: he cannot deny himself."*
>
> 2 TIMOTHY 2:13 — KJV

There is a question underneath everything this book has walked through so far, and it deserves to be asked directly: if mercy kept Jerusalem from being consumed, and if Christ's covering answers what sin exposed, what happens when we fail again after that? What happens when the same patterns of drift, the same quiet tearing of the covering, the same wandering from nearness, show up not once but repeatedly, long after we thought we had learned the lesson?

2 Timothy 2:13 answers this with a statement that should stop us: "if we believe not, yet he abideth faithful: he cannot deny himself." Paul is not describing a mercy that depends on our consistency. He is describing a faithfulness anchored entirely in God's own unchanging character — which means our unfaithfulness, real as it is, does not get the final vote on whether His covering holds.

This is not a license for careless living, and the rest of scripture is careful to say so — "shall we continue in sin, that grace may abound? God forbid" (Romans 6:1-2). But it is an answer to a very real fear many believers carry quietly: the fear that mercy has a limited number of uses, that eventually the well runs dry, that this time — this particular failure — might finally be the one that exhausts God's patience. 2 Timothy 2:13 says plainly: His faithfulness was never running on a meter that counted our

failures toward a limit. It runs on His own nature, which does not change.

> *"For I am the LORD, I change not; therefore ye sons of Jacob are not consumed."*
>
> **MALACHI 3:6, KJV**

Malachi 3:6 draws the connection explicitly, in language that echoes Lamentations 3:22 almost word for word: "ye sons of Jacob are not consumed" — not because Jacob's descendants had become faithful, but because the LORD "change not." The reason God's people across both testaments survive their own repeated failures is never their improved performance. It is His unimproved, unchangeable character. He does not become more faithful when we behave better, and He does not become less faithful when we don't. Faithfulness, by definition, cannot be partial or conditional — otherwise it would simply be a longer version of conditional love.

Consider Peter, who denied Christ three times in a single night, the third time with cursing (Mark 14:71), after being warned directly that it would happen. By any reasonable accounting, that failure should have ended something. Instead, the risen Christ's first recorded message after the resurrection singles Peter out by name — "go your way, tell his disciples and Peter" (Mark 16:7) — and later restores him personally, three times, matching the three denials exactly (John 21:15-17). The restoration was not generic. It was aimed precisely at the specific failure, because faithfulness does not merely overlook our worst moments — it meets them directly and answers them fully.

This is the faithfulness this chapter wants us to actually believe, not just recite: the same mercy that kept a ruined Jerusalem from total consumption, the same robe that covered a prodigal before he finished his apology, the same patience that restored a disciple who had just denied Christ with an oath — none of it was ever measuring our consistency before deciding whether to hold. It was always measuring His own unchanging name. That is a mercy strong enough to survive our worst days, because it was never built on our best ones.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Coming Back Under the Covering

> *"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."*
>
> **1 JOHN 1:9 — KJV**

Everything this book has described so far — the covering we were given, the tear sin causes, the trampling that follows, the mercy that keeps us from being consumed, the better covering found in Christ, the faithfulness that does not change — still leaves one practical question unanswered: how does a person who has drifted from the covering actually come back under it? 1 John 1:9 gives the plainest possible answer: confess, and be covered again.

Notice what this verse does not require. It does not require a lengthy process of earning trust back, a probationary period, or proof of changed behavior sustained over time before forgiveness becomes available. It requires confession — an honest acknowledgment of what actually happened, without excuse or minimizing — and promises, in response, that God is "faithful and just" to forgive and to cleanse. Faithful, because this is exactly who He has always said He is. Just, because the cost of that forgiveness was already paid in full at the cross; granting it is not God bending His own justice, but honoring what justice has already settled.

> *"Rend your heart, and not your garments, and turn unto the LORD your God: for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and of great*

kindness."

JOEL 2:13, KJV

Joel's instruction — "rend your heart, and not your garments" — points at something important about what real confession actually involves. In the ancient world, tearing one's outer garment was a visible, public gesture of grief or repentance, and it could be performed without anything underneath actually changing. Joel redirects the tearing to where it matters: the heart itself, honestly broken over what was done, rather than a performance of brokenness staged for an audience. God is not interested in the theater of repentance. He responds to the reality of it.

Return again to the prodigal son, because Luke 15 gives us the clearest narrative picture of exactly this kind of return. The son's actual words of confession — "Father, I have sinned against heaven, and before thee, and am no more worthy to be called thy son" (v.21) — are almost an afterthought by the time he speaks them, because the father has already seen him "a great way off," already run to meet him, already embraced him before a single word of confession was spoken (v.20). This is worth noticing carefully: the robe, the ring, the feast — the full restoration of covering — was never contingent on the son finishing his rehearsed speech of self-deprecation. It was contingent only on him turning around and walking home.

This is the pattern 1 John 1:9 describes in doctrine and Luke 15 describes in story: coming back under the covering is not a complicated negotiation. It is turning, honestly, toward the One who was already watching for your return. The distance sin created feels, from the inside, like it should require an elaborate bridge to close. Scripture insists it requires only a turn — because

the Father was already running before the son ever finished walking.

If something in these chapters has surfaced a specific tear you have been carrying quietly — a place where the covering has worn thin, where you have felt exposed longer than you have admitted to anyone, including yourself — this is the invitation this chapter exists to extend. Not a program to complete. A confession to make, honestly, to a Father who is already faithful and just to answer it.

CHAPTER EIGHT

New Every Morning

> *"They are new every morning: great is thy faithfulness... He that dwelleth in the secret place of the most High shall abide under the shadow of the Almighty."*
>
> LAMENTATIONS 3:23, PSALM 91:1 — KJV

We end where chapter four turned, because it is worth returning to that verse once more with the rest of the book now behind us. "His compassions fail not. They are new every morning." Not renewed occasionally, when we have been especially faithful. Not restored once and then left to our own maintenance after that. New every morning — a mercy with no accumulated wear, no diminishing supply, available again today exactly as fresh as it was the day Jeremiah first wrote those words over a city in ruins.

This is the daily reality this book has been building toward, and it is worth being specific about what it actually looks like to live inside it, rather than leaving it as a beautiful but abstract idea. Living under a restored covering does not mean sin stops being a real danger, or that vigilance becomes unnecessary — Peter's warning about the roaring lion in chapter three remains just as true for someone walking in restored mercy as for anyone else. What changes is the posture: not a person constantly trying to rebuild a covering from scratch through performance, but a person who has learned to dwell, daily, in a covering that is already there.

> *"I will say of the LORD, He is my refuge and my fortress: my God; in him will I trust."*

PSALM 91:2, KJV

Psalm 91 describes this dwelling in physical, almost architectural language — "the secret place," "the shadow of the Almighty," a "refuge and fortress." These are not one-time destinations visited during a crisis and abandoned once things calm down. They are places of ongoing residence. The psalm pictures a person who has made their home inside God's nearness, so that when trouble comes — and the psalm is honest that it will — it finds someone already covered, already sheltered, rather than someone scrambling at the last moment to find protection they never maintained.

This is the practical difference between the fig leaves of chapter two and the robe of chapter five, lived out day by day rather than described in theory. Fig leaves require constant rebuilding — sewn fresh each time the old ones wither, never quite sufficient, always one storm away from failing again. The robe of righteousness does not wear out, because it was never made from anything we grew ourselves. Dwelling under it daily looks like continual nearness — scripture read not as obligation but as hearing the voice of the One we live with, prayer offered not as emergency signal flare but as ongoing conversation, confession offered quickly rather than let to fester, exactly as chapter seven described.

This is also the real answer to the fear that sits underneath so much of this book's subject matter: the fear that one more failure might finally be the one that exhausts mercy's supply. Lamentations 3:23 answers that fear not with a reassurance about our own improving performance, but with a fact about God's unchanging nature: the mercy is new *every morning*, which means tomorrow's mercy was never going to be yesterday's leftovers.

Whatever covering wore thin today, there is a fresh one waiting with the sunrise — not because the old one failed, but because His compassions were never designed to run on a finite reserve in the first place.

The covering we were given in Eden was lost in a single disobedient moment. The covering restored to us in Christ cannot be lost the same way, because it never depended on our unbroken performance to begin with — it depends on a faithfulness that does not change, offered fresh every single morning to anyone who will turn and dwell under it. Whatever sin has cost you, whatever the enemy has trampled, whatever tear you have been quietly carrying: you are not consumed. His mercies will meet you again tomorrow morning, exactly as new as they were today.

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